



HI! I'M MARIA.

I'm an established marketing professional with both client- and agency-side experience. I can easily adapt to new categories and have a wide range of proven skills. I've worked with major brands and here are some examples I'm most proud of:

MERCEDES-BENZ UKRAINE

Automotive · Ukraine · 2015–2018

SIGNIFY

Smart lighting · UK & Europe · 2022–2024

WWF-UK

Charity · UK · 2023–2024

MERCEDES-BENZ UKRAINE

Holding premium positioning through price challenges

Automotive · Ukraine · 2015–2018 · in-house



MERCEDES-BENZ UKRAINE

Automotive · Ukraine
2015–2018 · in-house



CONTEXT

After 2014 Ukraine's car market went through tough times. An imported premium car became much more expensive in local currency. In 2015 Mercedes-Benz sold only ~1,430 cars — almost the same as its main competitor, BMW.

So, my task was not only to adapt a brand with strict global guidelines and strategy to local audience specifics, but also to keep its premium positioning in a segment that had to compete on discounts.

APPROACH

Price messaging without repositioning.

The sales department ran clearance campaigns once or twice a year. Discounts bring short-term sales but don't sustain growth and are harmful to premium perception. So, I kept the core brand message while testing price appeal with softer wording like "special offers" or "attractive prices, ask for details" and ran tests to choose the one that performed better/

Media decisions based on post-campaign analysis.

I planned for every digital campaign based on previous channel metrics and Google analytics data (reviewed reach and frequency, VTR, CTR, bounce rate, session depth and time on site etc.) and moved budget to what worked. Some digital channels weren't adopted by the brand back then, so Programmatic and Meta Ads first entered the mix. As a result, cost per reach fell and site engagement improved.

MY RESPONSIBILITIES

- National brand campaigns from brief to launch, control and post-campaign analysis,
- Negotiated placements and contracts with agencies, TV, radio stations, web resources,
- Messaging frameworks; global brand guidelines localisation,
- Creative production: video, radio, digital, print,
- Brand-owned media: brand website, dealer websites across Ukraine, brand magazine localisation and publishing,
- Part of the team delivering brand events, responsible for organisation and brand standards.

Optimized placement through negotiation.

I kept the efficient approach to brand's campaigns, this means quality placements at controlled cost, agreed directly with agencies and media owners of paying standard rates.

National consistency across a dealer network.

To keep the brand consistent across every media touchpoint, I've collected local business input from dealer marketing teams across Ukraine for national campaigns and tracked their webpages, adverts, socials were aligned with the brand guidelines.

Brand events.

I was part of the small team responsible for big events like new model launch events, brand sports events, fashion activations and high-quality partnerships.

MY ROLE
Brand Communication Manager (in-house)

MERCEDES-BENZ UKRAINE

Automotive · Ukraine
2015–2018 · in-house



IMPACT

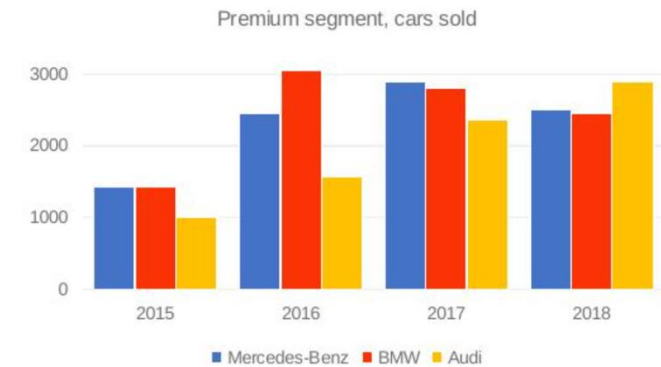
First in the premium segment by 2017, and ahead of BMW after it

MY CONTRIBUTION:

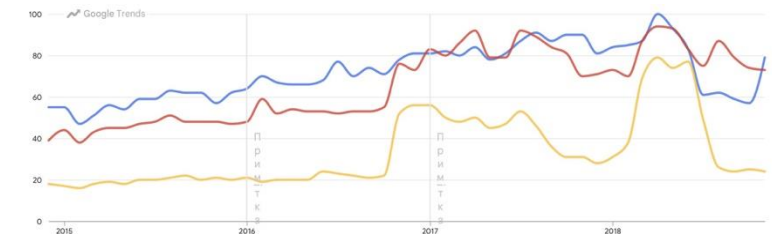
- Up to 10 national campaigns a year across digital, radio, TV, press — including model launches, range campaigns, clearance,
- Annual campaign budget around UAH 8–12M,
- ~800K paid reach at frequency 6 and ~18K site visits per campaign (3–4 weeks long),
- Campaigns ran consistently through the year rather than in short bursts. Brand salience grew steadily over the period, supported by Google Trends data and sales. Of course, communication was one of many factors in the brand ecosystem, but continuous presence was part of it.
- ~250 cars a month converted by the dealer network at peak. My side was keeping the brand visible through a long consumer decision cycle.

MARKET RESULTS:

- The brand recovered from ~1,430 cars sold (2015) to 2,897 in 2017, becoming first in the premium segment.
- Kept the position ahead of its main competitor, BMW, in 2018, when Audi disrupted the premium segment with heavily discounted diesel stock.
- Brand interest grew steadily across the period (Google Trends).



Brand interest across the period — Google Trends



SIGNIFY

Leading media strategy across six European markets

Smart lighting / consumer tech · UK & Europe · 2022–2024 (Merkle)



SIGNIFY

Smart lighting / consumer tech
UK & Europe · 2022–2024 (Merkle)

MY ROLE
Senior Strategic Planning Manager at
Merkle, Media Strategy Lead on the Signify
account across key European markets.



CONTEXT

Signify is the world's largest lighting company. Its connected portfolio includes Philips Hue as the premium ecosystem brand and WiZ as the accessible one, alongside conventional Philips LED sold through retail.

The global team owned the brand framework. My responsibility was turning the framework into a working strategy for the UK, DACH, Benelux and the Nordics as the main markets, with Italy and Spain at smaller scale, and to lead the brand activities through the year.

Two things made it difficult.

The first was consistency: six markets planning and buying at the same time, each with its own brand health, competitors, retail structure and budget.

The second was the period itself. Signify's group sales fell from €7.5bn in 2022 to €6.7bn in 2023, including the Digital Products division. The smart lighting category was shrinking and demand fell across 2022–2023. European retailers were reducing stock and first-time buyers were moving to cheaper Wi-Fi bulbs.

Every premium brand in the category had the same year. So, brand investment was reduced quarter by quarter in response, and every planning cycle became a balance between what the business could afford and what happens to a brand without advertising.

MY RESPONSIBILITIES

- Market-level brand communication and media strategy for six European markets, built from the global framework with annual and campaign planning across the brand portfolio with focus on Philips Hue,
- Full campaign ownership: from client brief through planning, briefing and coordinating channel specialists (paid social, programmatic, PPC, TV, OOH, radio, press), in-flight optimisation, and post-campaign analysis and recommendations,
- Audience definition and sizing, competitor tracking, market and consumer research for each market,
- Budget forecasting and investment recommendations needed to move brand metrics, rather than only allocating the budget that came with the brief,
- Campaign architecture across the customer decision journey: audiences, channel roles, messaging by stage, formats, timings,
- Direct communication with client marketing leads in each market, and the reporting cycle including QBRs, PCAs, H1/H2 reviews,
- Media updates for the client on what was new, keeping both sides on the same page about what to test and prepare for, with suggestions on media mix efficiency improvement.

APPROACH

Aligning the whole team around the strategy.

Leading media across six markets is as much a coordination job as a strategic one. Channel teams were briefed at every stage with the strategic context and the client's feedback, not only the task, so the whole team worked in one direction. Kanban plans made every step, owner and deadline visible to both sides, and told the client what we needed from them and when, so campaigns launched on time and channel teams were not left building overnight. The strategy was executed holistically, not as a collection of plans.

Keeping the brand coherent across the markets of different size.

While the brand's positioning, value pillars, calendar of brand events and persona approach were global, channels, audience approach, timings, message architecture across the consumer journey, product priority, media KPIs and the given budget had to be managed per market. Each market was assessed separately using the client's brand tracking, GWI data, competitor activity and search demand, and these often pointed in different directions.

✓ *For example, on 2022 tracking, Benelux and DACH were already at ~50-60% awareness, so the priority there was the drop-off into consideration. The UK, at ~45% awareness and ~9% preference, needed both a bigger audience at the top and better conversion through the funnel. Smaller markets like Italy and Spain were lower at every stage as the smart lighting category was not mature.*

My role was to create a practical strategy where the global recommendation had no solution for the market.

✓ *For instance, in the UK I costed the audience at each stage of the funnel and focused on the top, putting about 1.4 times more into awareness than the client had recommended. Only ~9% of budget covered everyone who already had Hue, meaning that group was not underfunded; it was just small. The main job was to grow the number of people entering the "funnel", not to work harder on retention.*

Optimizing the global audience approach for more effective reach.

Initially the client had been using the "persona" approach which led to unnecessary fragmentation in targeting and communication while building brand awareness. The audience data showed ~30% overlap between them. From late 2022 the top of the funnel was consolidated across every market into one shared audience with one brand message, while persona and proposition work moved down the funnel, as someone who already owns a bridge and could add to it needs a different message from someone who has never heard of Hue. Broad reach at the top with specific messages below it.

Running brand communication despite the budget cuts.

Hue had to hold a premium price against cheaper competitors while the cost-of-living crisis was hitting all European markets. That led to marketing budget cuts for brand campaigns, with some performance as well. Rather than let the upper and mid funnel stop running, we combined channel optimisation for reach and consideration metrics in our media plans, with aligned creatives in rotation, so brand building continued. Additionally, the timings were refined, as competitor tracking showed that almost all paid activity was focused on Q4 with long periods of media silence, so campaigns were launched ahead of competitors and small-budget bursts went into the weeks when nobody else was active. At the same time, demand was still followed, with nothing spent in the dead season just to be present. This way brand communication continued to attract new users while the promotional layer helped to convert, so discounting never became the brand message.

IMPACT

A continuous, competitive voice on a smaller budget

Securing relative brand position.

While the whole category was falling and the brand budget was being reduced, the main impact of my day-to-day work was in securing relative brand position. By funding the upper and mid funnel through combined plans, buying presence in the periods competitors left empty, optimising audience reach, and keeping media efficiency within the benchmarks, Hue kept a continuous and competitive voice on a smaller budget.

- ✓ On our own competitive tracking, Hue held the strongest organic visibility in the category throughout the period, with the closest competitor closing the gap in Q4 and falling back again in Q1.

Seamless aligned work around Six busy markets

- ✓ with roughly six campaign moments per market each year over a permanent always-on layer (~€1.9M annual media budget for one market alone) and ad-hoc client requests **outside** the planned activity including extra briefs, one-off research questions, recommendations,

Managed the campaigns to maintain the efficiency.

Worked with the channel teams as campaigns ran, deciding where brand lift studies were needed, which messages to keep in rotation and which to drop, how to improve metrics campaign by campaign and whether the brand message was still reaching the audience we planned for at each stage of the consumer journey.

- ✓ *In the UK, for example, awareness activity on YouTube delivered a 1.9% lift (24% cheaper CPLU than the previous quarter), and Performance Max, which we recommended adding when Google released it, returned 1.3 times the ROAS of the text ads alongside it.*

Led and coordinated cross-functional teams of up to seven channel specialists and third-party media owners.

WWF-UK

Proving the case for brand investment in a performance-led fundraising business

Charity / conservation · UK · 2023–2024 (Merkle)





CONTEXT

WWF is the world's leading independent conservation organisation. Its UK arm is among the best-known charities in the country and is funded mainly by private donations.

To raise funds WWF uses one-off donations, lotteries, symbolic animal adoptions, membership, a children's product, retail and emergency appeals. Each has its own barrier to entry, acquisition cost and lifetime value. Although the core business goal is income, the brand splits its budget between brand and fundraising.

OBJECTIVE

The client's main task is to grow income by increasing the number of supporters and long-term revenue. The Fund aims to hit targets in a challenging environment and strike the balance between short-term cashflow and long-term support. The communications task is to establish WWF as the leading voice bringing our world back to life, changing outcomes for nature and climate.

On the client side the main part of the budget was focused on fundraising (with performance campaigns), while the brand budget had been cut over several years. WWF therefore also asked for strategies that would soften the absence of brand investment.

MY RESPONSIBILITIES

- Annual strategy and the planning of individual campaigns through the year,
- Continuous analysis of brand health, its communication, the competitive environment and media effectiveness,
- Audience strategy: rebuilding the client's segment approach to create a coherent communication strategy at the level of the brand and of individual fundraising propositions.
- Communication and creative direction: which topics and moments the brand appears around, what makes it stand out in a category where everyone looks alike, what behavioural principles the message is built on, and in which formats it runs.
- Running advertising activity from the client brief to the post-campaign analysis: channel recommendations and budget allocation, briefs to channels, in-flight optimisation, preparation of the PCA,
- Preparing recommendations to raise conversion rates: aligning media, messages and landing pages, synchronising CRO tests with channel tests, the quality of traffic and leads.

THE PROBLEM

We ran a thorough analysis of brand health, the category, the target audience and the effectiveness of media, communication and performance, and identified several barriers:

We were working with demand that already existed.

At the same time, in terms of lifetime value, pure brand terms brought 21% of all LTV and took only 6% of the search budget. In other words, performance was harvesting what the brand had built earlier.

Brand demand itself had been falling for more than one year.

Brand awareness declined gradually over five years by around 7 percentage points, and branded search was trending downwards. Animal adoption queries were losing a significant share of organic clicks, although the brand held the top positions: it was demand that was disappearing, not our presence in the results. Protecting our own brand terms became roughly twice as expensive over the year.

Existing digital audiences were becoming saturated.

Taking social media and brand lift studies as an example, we saw saturation of the target audience and the need to improve the segment approach.

WWF was behind the category on media scale.

The largest investors, with a full mix that includes TV, were gaining awareness and stronger brand metrics. And the share of fundraising volume influenced by media grew by around 1.2 times, while the share that came without advertising fell accordingly.

Communication in the category often looked the same.

You could put any brand's logo into any advertisement in the category, and on top of that the same creative was often left running unchanged for a long time. So, building distinctiveness and relevance had significant potential in working with the audience's attention.

The cost-of-living crisis was narrowing the wallet:

the ongoing strain of Cost of Living also means many are cutting back how much and to how many charities they can donate to, increasing competition for attention and share of wallet.

The main goal of the project was therefore defined as to invest in the brand by building effective reach and keeping the brand relevant in communication, while maintaining the effectiveness of performance campaigns.



MY SOLUTIONS & IMPACT

The client entered the next year with consistent brand & fundraising architecture, optimized audience strategy and tested communication solutions.

A complete audience strategy.

WWF's segments were rebuilt, their sizes counted, deduplication carried out, overlaps and shared characteristics identified (the potential size of the target donor audience grew by seven times) – that is, growth lay outside the core, not inside it. A consistent architecture of audiences, messages and media KPIs was developed.

- ✓ **As a result:** the brand stopped spending extra money to reach the same people several times, which allowed the media budget to be optimized; within a test campaign the broader segment group logically achieved a CPM around 1.5 times lower on average; brand and fundraising began working within one consistent frame (a broad audience and one shared brand message, with engagement built through personal product messages and more precise targeting).

Recommendations to strengthen the brand's salience and relevance through context.

Messages were built on the issues that are genuinely close to the audience. A calendar of moments was then assembled with WWF's own events, the seasonality of the category and cultural occasions chosen in advance.

- ✓ A campaign tied to a cultural moment lifted branded paid search: +18% impressions and +22% clicks. Separately, contextual creative delivered the strongest conversions. For example, the test creative took 29% of the month's conversions at a CPA 10% below the campaign average.

Distinctive assets and donor behavior.

To increase brand recognition in the category, I put together proposals for the creative. Although WWF has clear guidelines, the visual language of the top competitors uses similar images of animals and nature. WWF's recognisable black-and-white logo, fonts and text panels must therefore be used strictly and consistently across all communication, because even simply the "wrong" font in a social video costs the brand its memory structures.

I also recommended building creative in line with behavioural research on what drives participation in charity: to highlight stories relevant to the UK regions; to trigger empathy through bright details and heart-touching stories; to create a sense that even the smallest amounts matter.

- ✓ **In testing,** the algorithm gave 94% of the budget to expressive video with storytelling, and the only British animal in the set took 68% of the budget and delivered a matching 69% of leads.

The case for brand investment within the annual planning.

Binet and Field's work on long-term effects, consistent with the brand's own local econometrics. This analysis helped to convince the client to buy reach across the whole base continuously rather than in bursts to feed the conversions in the long term/

Alongside the brand work, fundraising performance campaigns ran continuously.

With channel and CRO teams: alignment of offer, advertising, traffic source and landing page; channels chosen on traffic and lead quality; both CPA and LTV managed.

- ✓ In a campaign during the most competitive period of the year we exceeded the fundraising target by 10%.

HAPPY TO DISCUSS ALL THE DETAILS

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